

.Excerpts from *The Sikhs in History* by Sangat Singh

It is truism to say that during his victories in various battles especially against the hill chiefs, Guru Gobind Singh did not occupy an inch of territory. But throughout his life, he was not oblivious of the importance of political power as a catalyst of social change. Over a decade before the creation of the Khalsa, at the time of battle of Bhangani, he had enunciated the doctrine that "Without political power, *dhanna* (the rule of law) can not be established; and without *dharma* the society was an admixture of scum", or "Religion without political freedoms and dignity was an abject slavery, and politics without religious morality was an organised barbarism." Political power, as such, was a mean to attain the objectives viz., "to uphold the saints and destroy the wicked."

Guru Gobind Singh was overwhelmed by the response he got from all sections of society particularly the lower ones in the creation of Khalsa - an end product of over 200 years of endeavours of the Sikh Gurus. That was right upto his expectations. Already, the living spirit of the Guru had widened the horizon of their mind, and now the boon of baptism with emphasis on the plying of the sword to uphold the righteousness, changed the physical characteristics of the Khalsa. In his talks with Bhai Nand Lal, Guru Gobind Singh spelled out his resolve to confer the rulership of the land on these downtrodden people.

For instance, the 'Khalsa Mehma' also known as 'Khalsa Nama' (now in *Sarb Loh Granth*), which was mischievously excluded from the so-called *Dasam Granth*, contains Guru Gobind Singh's high appraisal of the Khalsa in glowing terms as 'my spirit', 'my faith', 'my best friend', 'my honour and dignity', 'in whom I repose all my attention', who is 'part of an ocean as a drop of water is', and so on. In saying that, as mentioned earlier, he affirmed, "I am not mentioning an iota of a falsehood for I am holding Guru Nanak (who is like) *parbrahm* (to me) as a witness." It was in this context, that Guru Gobind Singh wanted the Khalsa to keep its distinct character and not fall a victim to *bipran ki reet* the rites of non-conforming faiths. He is not mentioning it in singular *bipar*, but in plural *bipran*, i.e. Brahminical contrivances. This hymn was obviously composed during the last phase of Guru Gobind Singh's life, and laid emphasis on three aspects of the Sikh life: firstly, continuation of mission of Guru Nanak to its final culmination, stage; two, relevance of Guru Nanak's teachings of humanity for all times to come, and their uniqueness; and three, warning the Khalsa or the Sikhs of the Brahministic faiths. It may be kept in mind that Hinduism was not one faith, but a hotchpotch assortment of conflicting doctrines and dogmas. These constituted an obvious threat. ²²⁵

Again, referring to the people from the so-called low castes, joining the fold of Khalsa, he was reported to have said:

The people in whose caste/sub-caste smaller or bigger brotherhood, no one ever became a leader of men, I shall make these very people rulers of men/land, only then shall I be called Gobind Singh.

Bhai Nand Lal's minutes in his *Tankhah Nama* summed up in the litany *raj karega khalsa* (Khalsa shall rule) inspired the Khalsa to new heights, and set the guidelines for the post-Khalsa period. The *Amamamah* (October 1708) of Nathmal Dhadi also vouchsafes that the "Sikhs have been granted sovereignty of both the worlds, and must retain high spirits under all circumstances. "

The Khalsa, in short, was an embodiment of humankind - an integrated product of men from all castes, including the downcastes and outcastes. Ethnic equality constituted the core of the brotherhood of the Khalsa. The Khalsa had three distinct characteristics; to be physically distinct, mentally alert and spiritually enlightened. The Khalsa had the team spirit, *esprit de corps*. The Khalsa spirit was harnessed in the service of man, society and state. The Khalsa was fully alive to the social needs to protect the human rights of the weak and the deprived. He was committed to oppose and halt the progress of tyranny and oppression of a person or state, and eradicate the evil. The Khalsa was a householder and yet a saint. The Khalsa was a soldier to uphold the values he held dear. The concept of the Khalsa was based on martyrdom. Therefore, the Khalsa was not afraid to die for worthy causes. Since the Khalsa upheld the social values, it constituted a revolutionary force.

3 Factors In Rise And Fall of The Sikh Power (1708 - 1849)

The political position of the Sikhs at the time of assassination of Guru Gobind Singh in 1708 was that of guerrillas. After a gruesome struggle of almost six decades they earned a place under the sun and emerged as sovereigns of the Punjab.

I

This period of the Sikh history or that of the Punjab has been painted with a dark brush by contemporary Mughal historians who presented the well entrenched forces of the status quo. The Sikhs, who constituted the revolutionary class, and emerged on the top in the quadrangular struggle for supremacy involving the Mughals, the Marathas, the Afghans and themselves, left no first hand account of their objectives, tactics or motivation.

The worst part of it was that the Sikh chroniclers who followed were either those left on the fringes in the ongoing struggle, or were infiltrators and felt themselves uneasy in the emerging milieu. They tended to distort the nature of the struggle by giving it a sectarian twist, in the process, making it look anti-Muslim and/or pro-Hindu. And, the twist came to stay during the 19th century and for the best part of the present one.

The modern historians mostly followed the Mughal chroniclers. By publishing the account of the period in the English language, they gave a degree of acceptance and respectability to this partisan history. The Sikhs who, from the position of being underdogs, emerged as sovereigns of the Punjab in 1765 went unrepresented while the vanquished Mughals and Afghans garnered the bulk in the traditional historical accounts of the period. Lack of training in writing the history of guerrilla movement, or personal predilections in refusal to recognise the distinct character of the Khalsa nationalism, which needed a separate treatment, or possibly both, lay at the roots of this lopsidedness.

II

To begin with, we may look into the objective situation of the Sikhs in 1708. The assassination of Guru Gobind Singh in the South (Deccan) far away from the Punjab, the center of Sikhism, left the Sikhs in a poignant situation.

Firstly, the Khalsa now barely nine and a half years old (but with a background of 200 years) represented an unfinished revolution.

Secondly, Guru Gobind Singh abolished personal guruship and bequeathed the Guruship spiritually to the *Sri Guru Granth Sahib* and corporately to the cumulative *Panth*, i.e. the whole community. Both these concepts of *Granth* and *Panth* needed to be ingrained into Sikh psyche which was hampered by the difficult situation in which the Khalsa was placed during this period.

Guru Gobind Singh had transformed the character of his disciples, deeply inspired the Khalsa and provided it with a high degree of motivation - a revolutionary ideology.

For a proper appreciation of the character of the Khalsa and its ideological motivation, we shall have to go back a bit to Guru Gobind Singh's saying very clearly that the purpose of his Guruship was to uphold righteousness, protect the poor and down trodden and uproot the evildoers. This combined with Guru Tegh Bahadur's prescription (*bhai kahoo ko det neh, neh bhai manat an*), that we shall not oppress anyone, nor knuckle under oppression, provided the clear politico-religious framework for the Khalsa.

The Khalsa was involved in a fight against tyranny and oppression. It was a religious war in the sense that the Khalsa was inspired by religious ideals to fight against oppression, but not a religious war in the sense of fight against the Muslims or Islam. For, it was not.

Guru Gobind Singh himself during the pre-Khalsa and post-Khalsa period had fought against tyranny in all its denominations - against the incorrigible hill chiefs, the Mughal Governors and the imperial forces. He had Muslims in his army, and did not mince words in calling a spade a spade, be it a Hindu or a Muslim oppressor. And, at the height of the crisis, it were the Muslim friends who had helped him to escape both from Chamkaur and Machhiwara to Malwa! For the Khalsa, in the post-Guru Gobind Singh period, non-sectarianism was an important principle; an article of faith, not to be lost sight of.

As such, the objectives of the Khalsa were, firstly, political, to fight against tyranny, and, secondly, in the face of wholesale oppression and persecution, of survival without letting the movement, despite provocations, to take a sectarian, anti-Muslim turn.

III

Now, we may turn to the objective situation in the Punjab in the post-Aurangzeb and post-Guru Gobind Singh period. The various aspects which come forth are as follows.

Firstly, Aurangzeb's policy of religious intolerance had brought about a schism between the Hindus and the Muslims throughout the empire; the impact being mild or severe depending upon local circumstances. The *suba* of Sirhind especially constituted a reactionary *suba* known for an intensification of religious intolerance, especially because of the influence on the administration of Islamic puritans represented by the *Sajada Nashins* of Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi Mujaddid Alaf Sani with headquarters at Sirhind.

Secondly, the rise of the militant Khalsa introduced a unique factor in the religious composition of the Punjab, making it a tri-religious state, which placed it apart from other parts of India with Hinduism and Islam as the two dominant religions. Therefore, the Punjab historically needed a separate treatment.

Thirdly, as we have seen, the rise of Khalsa, mainly taking converts from the low and middle class Hindus, in the process making them self assertive and militant, had made the upper class of Hindus - mainly Brahmins, and clannish hill rulers etc, rabidly anti-Sikh. This alignment was widened in Farrukhsiyar's period to include sections of Khattris and Baniyas, the moneyed and business classes, who thought it advisable to align with the Mughal administration. Faced by a rising tide of Sikh

militancy, the administration thought it prudent to follow a policy of religious tolerance towards the Hindus as against systematic persecution of the Sikhs. This, at times, led to collaboration between the upper caste Hindus and the Mughal administration. It must be understood that a section of Punjabi or North Indian Hindus was not reconciled to the emergence of the Khalsa which struck at the roots of the Brahminical culture of *varnashram dharma*. They were as much inimical to the Sikhs as the Mughals or the Afghans, displaced from political power by the Khalsa, could be.

Lastly, the social egalitarianism represented by the militant Khalsa especially endeared itself to the poor populace/peasantry, alienated by an oppressive regime. It were these segments which provided recruits to the brotherhood of the Khalsa and did not let the movement dwindle, despite heavy losses in manpower that systematic persecution entailed. It must be understood that these new entrants needed a high degree of religious orientation, which was not available after the martyrdom of Bhai Mani Singh and the death of Nawab Kapur Singh.

IV

The Sikhs emerged on the political scene of the Punjab and northern India under the leadership of Banda Singh Bahadur who was especially commissioned by Guru Gobind Singh to initiate the process of political change and reform.

It is a pity that some of the historians out of ignorance or mischief have sought to make out that the Khalsa which, they agree, represented the new wave and constituted a reckonable force, at this crucial juncture was not led by one who himself belonged to the faith. Their contention that Banda was not baptised and did not take the *Pahul* (baptism) stems out of jaundiced mind, for various reasons.

Firstly, they do not adequately explain how Lachman Dev Bairagi got the name Banda Bahadur as they give it out. ~If he had subjected his ego to that of Guru Gobind Singh and accepted his leadership as his *banda* (devotee) it beats one's intelligence that Lachman Dev would either refuse the boon of *Pahul* or that Guru Gobind Singh would deny him that boon. He got the name Banda Singh only after taking the *Pahul*.

Secondly, it is hard to think that either Guru Gobind Singh would appoint a non-anointed Sikh, who had reservations in taking *Pahul*, as the leader of the Khalsa, or that Banda would agree to lead such a highly devoted and dedicated corps without his taking *Pahul*, which constituted the bond of brotherhood of the force, which Banda expected to lead and which inspired his forces to extraordinary feats of heroism and bravery. His detractors tend to project that Banda was peevish in character, either a naive or a fool, which, they agree, he was not.

Thirdly, it is contended that Ahmad Shah Butalia who, to their knowledge, was the first to write about Banda's baptism did so a hundred years after the occasion and that he wrote without any contemporary historical evidence. They ignore or had no knowledge of the writings of men like Koer Singh (1751), Swarup Singh (1790), and others. Not only that, the motivations of trying to appease the Sikh ruler, Maharaja Ranjit Singh or Sikh Sardars, are attributed to Butalia. Both arguments are fallacious: they do not take into cognisance the evidence of oral history and attribute a zeal to Maharaja Ranjit Singh and to Sikh Sardars to falsify the Sikh history, which they did not have.

Lastly, they do not accept Butalia's historical writing but blindly accept Khafi Khan and other Muslim contemporary writers' description of Banda as a bloody monster. It is not that Ahmad Shah Butalia wrote a biased, motivated, history, but that these modern writers do not want to use the faculties of modern historiography and open up the windows of their mind.

V

Banda Singh took almost a year to surface near Delhi. His *hukmnamahs* to Sikh *sangats* to repair to him fully armed evoked instant response. The people of Malwa straightaway gathered under his banner, while those from Majha and Doaba moved in an organised manner to arrive at Kiratpur, after fighting their way across the Malerkotla Pathans who blocked their way on the Sutlej. In due course, according to Ghulam Mohyuddin (*Fatuhāt Namah-i-Samādī*, 1722-23) "people as far as Iran, Turan, Kandhar, Multan and neighboring climes and countries" started pouring into the Punjab in large numbers in disguise or even openly by the beat of the drum.

Banda Singh's proclamation calling upon all those who had suffered at the hands of oppressive Zamindars, or were tormented by anti-social elements, bullies and despots. to join him to get justice, opened up a Pandora's box. It evoked an overwhelming response from people of all faiths, including Hindus and Muslims - to create vistas for a people's revolution. Banda Singh moved in a calculated manner to create general disorder and contempt for the imperial authority.

He ransacked the state treasury and the houses of the rich at Sonapat and worsted the small detachment carrying government treasury at Kaithal, of both cash and horses. In his first major action, he stormed Samana² on November 26, 1709, leaving 10,000 dead, and followed up by routing Faujdars of Kapuri and Mustafabad.

That brought him to Sadhaura whose chief, Usman Khan, had earned the ire of Guru Gobind Singh because of his torturing of Pir Badruddin alias Buddhu Shah and his disciples to death for their role in the Guru's escape from Machhiwara to Malwa. The Hindus of the town whose houses used to be desecrated with cow's flesh by Usman Khan and his men, rose in revolt and went out of control. A general

massacre followed including of those who had taken shelter in Pir Buddhu Shah's house, now renamed *Qatalgarhi*, slaughter-fortress. Baba Banda Singh, in remorse, took a firm decision not to permit in future an attack on places of religious worship, or let the struggle be reduced to a sectarian strife.

Banda Singh skirted Sirhind, and those awaiting at Kiratpur joined him. He was now ready for an attack on Subedar Wazir Khan of Sirhind against whom the Sikhs had a special animus. Wazir Khan in self-defence made Mullahs to raise cries of *Jehad*, religious war, against the Sikhs. He also used Diwan Sucha Nand's nephew to infiltrate with a 1,000 strong force into the opposing camp to kill Banda if possible, or to desert his forces after having joined him, so as to cause general demoralisation. Wazir Khan moved out 10 miles to Chapar Chiri to face Banda's forces which were ill-equipped but led by veterans of the wars of Guru Gobind Singh. In the fierce battle on May 12, 1710, despite large scale desertions from Banda's forces, especially of those who had come purely with motivations of plunder, Wazir Khan was killed and his forces routed. They were pursued up to Sirhind which submitted two days later.

On the fall of Sirhind, Banda Singh treated Hindus and Muslims alike. The town was ransacked for three days when he, to the chagrin of his troops, stopped the pillage. The Mausoleum of Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi, Mujaddad Alif Sani, the doyen of Islamic fundamentalism and tormentor of the Sikhs, remained untouched.

The entire territory from Kamal to Ludhiana lay at his feet. The contemporary Muslim historians, though full of choicest invectives against the Sikhs as "wretched and worthless dogs", "hellish infidels", "fanatical ruffians", and Banda Singh himself as a "veritable monster", the vocabulary which we find throughout the Muslim writing on the Sikhs in the 18th century,³ were high praise for their reckless bravery.

Banda Singh now assumed the title of Bahadur and set to organise the administration. Baj Singh was appointed Governor of Sirhind with Ali Singh (formerly in service of Subedar of Sirhind) as his deputy. The appointment of Fateh Singh (son of Baj Singh) as head of administration of Samana was confirmed while Ram Singh' (younger brother of Baj Singh) and Binod Singh got the joint charge of Thanesar and the surrounding territory. A host of other appointments followed. From now onwards, Khalsa began to recite the couplet, *raj karega Khalsa* (Khalsa shall rule), in their congregations as part of their litany.⁴

Banda Singh chose Mukhlispur at the foot of Himalayas as his headquarters. He introduced a new calendar dating from his capture of Sirhind and struck coins as a mark of Sikh sovereignty. He appointed Sikhs from low classes "a low scavenger or leather dresser, the lowest of the low in Indian estimation" as Irvine puts it as *thanedars* and *tehsildars* in his *parganas*.⁶ He abolished Zamindari - the institution of absentee landlordism and made tillers of the soil the proprietors. That was applicable to tillers of all classes whether Sikh, Hindu or Muslim.

Ghulam Mohyuddin author of *Futuhāt Nama-i-Samadhi* (1722-23) who fought against Banda's forces and calls them "devils incarnate" and "a calamity on earth" testifies that Banda ruthlessly annihilated social inequalities born out of caste prejudices, enforced rigid abstinence of the Sikhs from adultery, and otherwise adopted codes of conduct for his forces "to present themselves as embodiment of moral values."

Banda Singh now made forays into the Gangetic valley. The uprising of the Gujjars who declared themselves *Nanak Prasth*, followers of Nanak, strengthened his forces. He overran Sharanpur, Behar, Ambheta, and Nanauta by July 1710 when he laid siege to Jalalabad. It had to be lifted because of pressing demands of the Sikhs from Doaba. ⁷

The Sikh uprising in Jalandar Doab came to successful fruition on October 3, 1710, when they drove out the forces of Faujdar Shams Khan from Rahon. Earlier, the Sikhs of Majha extended their sway up to the outskirts of Lahore. Significantly, at the battle of Kotla Begam near Batala, they permitted the Afghans of Sauri village, who did not want to fight, to retire unmolested. In a short time, the Sikhs were masters of the area from river Ravi to river Jumna. ⁸

Bahadur Shah was apprised of the news of Banda Singh's exploits on May 30, 1710, when he was at Ajmer. Taking into view the poignancy of the situation, he made up with the Rajputs and called for volunteers for *Jehad* against the Sikhs. He ordered mobilisation of the available forces as far as Oudh, rallied Bundhela Rajputs against the Sikhs and himself personally proceeded in person to the Punjab.

All Hindu employees were made to shave off their beards to distinguish them from the Sikhs. ⁹

After the rainy season, the Mughal military machine started rolling the Sikhs back from various positions right from Sonapat (October 22, 1710), through different towns down to the siege of Lohgarh fort (early December). Hundreds of Sikhs were killed at various places and their heads sent to the Emperor. Banda Singh, however, escaped on the night of December 10, 1710, towards Shivalik hills to the chagrin of Bahadur Shah who now issued orders from his camp near Lohgarh to Faujdars in the neighbourhood of Delhi "to kill the worshippers of Nanak (the Sikhs) wherever they are found". ¹⁰

Banda Singh within a fortnight started sending orders to the Sikhs to liberate the Punjab and join him at Kiratpur. Presently, he sought to secure his hinterland. His first victim was Raja Ajmer Chand of Kahlur (Bilaspur), the mastermind behind bringing about a confrontation between the Mughal administration and the Khalsa in the post-1699 period. Other hill chiefs submitted. The ruler of Chamba offered him his daughter in marriage. Later, he married second time.

It is to the credit of Banda Singh Bahadur that despite the stresses, he kept to the non-sectarian creed of the Khalsa. In spite of Bahadur Shah's provocative orders of outright extirpation of the Sikhs, Banda Singh according to the royal newswriter, while at Kalanaur in April 1711, has promised and proclaimed: "*We do not oppress the Muslims* or oppose Islam, but only tyranny and usurpation of power. Accordingly, for any Muslim who approaches him, he fixes a daily allowance and wages, and looks after him. He has permitted them to recite *Khutba* and *namaz*. As such, five hundred Muslims have gathered around him. Having entered into his friendship, they are free to shout their call - *bang* - and say their prayers - *namaz* - in the army of the wretched (Sikhs)".

Bahadur Shah's death in February 1712, at Lahore, gave Banda Singh some respite. But with the coming into power of Farrukhsiyar in another year, the campaign against the Sikhs was pursued with vigour and venom. Banda Singh, thereafter, had no positive achievement till his surrender at Gurdas Nangal in end-1715. He even failed to accept Binod Singh's sound advice to cut through the besieging forces and pursue guerrilla instead of conventional warfare.

Banda Singh Bahadur's successes were shortlived because of his lack of appreciation of the forces arraigned against him. If he were face to face with the oppressive forces in the Punjab only, he was and would have been a success. But the Mughal resources were vast - the whole of the empire. Banda Singh should have, firstly, confined merely to destruction of the oppressive forces and not tried to organise an alternative administration which made him overextend his meager resources. In other words, he should have continued to operate as a guerrilla leader rather than a conventional military leader which led to his defeat. Secondly, he violated Guru Gobind Singh's instructions regarding corporate leadership of the Khalsa, provided by the council of *panj piaras* (five beloved ones) named by him to aid and advise him. By appointing Baj Singh as Governor of Sirhind and Binod Singh and others to a miscellany of positions, he struck at the root of corporate leadership, and emerged as the sole and absolute leader.

Banda Singh, however, died a heroic death. It was remarkable that not a single of over 700 Sikhs, a majority of whom had been arbitrarily rounded up from the villages along the route when Banda Singh's caravan was being taken from Lahore to Delhi, reneged his faith. They smilingly courted martyrdom, the bulk of them in March 1716 and Banda Singh and his top aides in a gruesome manner on June 9, 1716.

Banda Singh's unconventional exploits touched the imagination of the populace and signified that oppressors were liable to be called upon to account for their sins of omission and commission. These singularly helped to unleash dynamic forces in the body politic and, despite the setbacks, instilled irrepressible confidence in the community.

Farrukhsiyar in 1716 issued an edict, fixing a price on the head of every Sikh. This led to their systematic persecution till at least his removal and death in 1719. He, however, brought about a fundamental change in the alignment of forces arraigned against the Sikhs. Renewing the orders of Bahadur Shah issued at the fag end of his life, he co-opted upper caste Hindus - Khattris, Brahmins and Banias - into the system of administration, and widened the schism between this section of the Hindus and the Sikhs.¹⁴

In a major reversal of policy, Farrukhsiyar in 1716 admitted the wrong done to Gangu Brahmin by Subedar Wazir Khan of Sirhind over a decade earlier in confiscating the gold, ornaments and coins misappropriated by him while betraying Guru Gobind Singh's mother and two younger sons to the Khan of Morinda. He now granted compensation to his son Raj Kaul in the form of land grant on *nehr* (canal) at Andha Mughal, a suburb of Delhi. As a camouflage, he straightaway dropped Kaul from his name, and added the surname Nehru, from the *Jagir* on *nehr* in Andha Mughal, Delhi.

In view of the rise of the Sikhs as a militant force in north-western India, the Mughal administration pursued a policy of tolerance towards the Hindus and their places of worship. The upper caste Hindus emerged as the greatest beneficiaries of the Mughal-Sikh conflict, and rather developed a vested interest in it both for keeping their positions and carrying on their war against Sikhism.

VI

In the post-Banda period, especially after the ignominious removal of Farrukhsiyar which gave the Sikhs some relief, they needed a wise leadership to ingrain the concept of the *Granth* and the *Panth* into the Sikh psyche. For a decade and a half, till his martyrdom, it was provided by Bhai Mani Singh, an erudite scholar, well versed in exposition of Sikh scriptures and Sikh philosophy.

It were his missionary tours explaining the Sikh scriptures that helped to leave an indelible mark of recognition of *Shabad* (the Word) as contained in the *Sri Guru Granth Sahib* as the guru. The point that Bhai Mani Singh instilled into the Sikh psyche was that *Shabad* as contained in the *Sri Guru Granth Sahib* in its entirety, without any distinctions, including the hymns of Bhaktas, was the Guru to be shown an equal degree of respect and reverence. Also, that the reverence was shown to the *word*, the hymns, and the volume of Sri Guru Granth Sahib was not worshiped as an idol.¹⁸

Bhai Mani Singh also exerted to bring about the recognition of Amritsar as politico-religious headquarters of Sikhism. It was the capital of Sikhism under Guru Ram Das, Guru Arjan and better part of Guru Hargobind's pontificate but had ceased to be so since 1634. Pilgrimages to places associated with the Gurus or with religious worship did not form part of the Sikh chore during the time of the Sikh Gurus.

The necessity arose when Bhai Mani Singh sought to translate the concept of Guru-Khalsa or *Sarbat Khalsa*, the whole community, as the corporate Guru. That was a democratic concept, far ahead of its times, and led to the concept of *Gurmatta*, or Guru's decision, taken by the community under the primacy of the *Akal Takht*.

Since the first recension of *Sri Guru Granth Sahib* had been installed at Harimandar, it helped to assert the position of Amritsar as the politico-religious headquarters of Sikhism. A pilgrimage to the tank of nectar and a visit to Harimandar got deeply ingrained in the Sikh psyche, and provided a powerful stimulus to the community as the fulcrum of its self-assertion during the dark days of the 18th century.

Another significant contribution of Bhai Mani Singh was the emergence of the medium of *Ardas*, the prayer, as a continuous-evolutionary process, which continues till today, recounting the deeds of Sikh heroes and martyrs to serve as a beacon light to the community in those hard-pressed days.

VII

The worst type of persecution to which the Sikhs were subjected, in the post Banda Singh period, drove the menfolk to abandon their houses and escape to jungles of the Punjab, Shivalik hills and deserts of Rajputana. Those were very hard times. Forced with privations and overwhelming odds, the Khalsa kept high spirits. In consonance with that, they coined their own vocabulary giving luxuriant names to humble things of daily use, such as almonds for grams, silver pieces for onion peels, green pulao for cooked leaves of trees, *maha parsad* to cooked meat, and so on.

From about 1720, there was some relaxation which led the government to pursue dual policy of repression and rapprochement. The upper caste Hindus co-opted into the system were not amused. The transfer of governorship of Lahore from Abdul Samad Khan to his son Zakaria Khan also known as Khan Bahadur activated both the government and the antagonistic Hindus led by Diwan Lakhpat Rai to form hunting parties to search and destroy the members of the Khalsa.

The principal Hindu actors on the hostile scene, besides Diwan Lakhpat Rai, were Chuhar Mal ahri of Amritsar, Deva the Chaudhary and his Brahmin Diwan Har Sahai of Patti, Sahib Rai the Chaudhary of Noshera, Pahar Mal grand son of Raja Todar Mal, Karma of Chhina, Rama Randhawa of Talwandi, Sahib Rai Sandhu of Noshera Datta and Harbhagat or Bhagat Naranjania of Jandiala. They acted as more royal than the king.

The objectives of inimical Hindus were no different from their imperial overlords. If the Mughal authorities ever offered the Sikhs a choice between Islam and death, the aspirations of Hindu hostiles were spelled out around 1726 by Sahib Rai of Patti to a couple of Sikhs who objected to grazing his horses in their fields; he threatened

them, saying, that "You talk of my horses trespassing into your fields. I tell you, my scissors will trespass into your beards and long hair."

The Sikh guerrillas during 1720s were led by Jathedar Darbara Singh. Their main operations consisted of raids on government treasuries, despoiling the small parties carrying revenue of cash, horses and armaments, mulcting of caravans and interfering in their free flow, and ravaging the houses of rich Zamindars. The efforts of Turkish nobles supplemented by Pahar Mal to raise Haidri Flag expedition to evict the entire Sikh population from their habitations in one big sweep, met a severe setback at the battle of Bhilowal between the crusaders and the Sikhs.²⁰ By early 1730s, the Sikhs had developed sufficient resources to be taken serious note of.

In a major reversal of policy, with the approval of the central government, Zakaria Khan now sought to co-opt the Sikhs into the system. He offered them the title of Nawab and a Jagir consisting of parganas of Dipalpur, Kanganwal, and Jhabal yielding an amount of rupees one hundred thousands. Services of Subeg Singh, a contractor (according to some a Persian knowing clerk in government service) were utilised to mediate between them and the Sikhs. He contacted the Khalsa in their Shivalik hideouts on the occasion of *Baisakhi* in end March 1733.

There could be only two candidates for Nawabi, Darbara Singh or his deputy, Kapur Singh. In the ensuing debate, Darbara Singh stated that Guru Gobind Singh "had promised us sovereignty. We cannot be content with a mere Nawabi". Eventually, after a great deal of discussion, it was decided to confer the title on Kapur Singh (b. 1697) who accepted the offer after the royal command was touched by feet by five leading Sikhs.²¹

The Sikhs now returned to their peaceful avocations in their villages. Nawab Kapur Singh organised the Sikhs into Buddha Dal consisting of war veterans of over 40 years of age to manage the shrines and do preaching work, and *Taruna Dal* of men under 40, a more active contingent to fight in times of emergency.²² Soon, *Taruna Dal* grew to a strength of 12,000 and had to be organised into five parts each having its own center.

These were led by 1. Deep Singh, 2. Harnam Singh and Sharam Singh, 3. Kahan Singh and Binod Singh, 4. Dasaunda Singh, and 5. Bir Singh and Jiwan Singh Rangrettas.²³ All castes, including the downcastes were fully represented.²⁴

The imperial authorities at Delhi were concerned at the process of consolidation of Sikhism. They suspected Zakaria Khan of advocating reconciliation with the Sikhs

with a view to assert his independence from Delhi. Zakaria Khan looked askance at the developments.

By the time, Bhai Mani Singh had asked for and was granted permission to organise a 10-day fair on the eve of Diwali at Amritsar on payment of a fee of Rs. 5,000. Harbhagat Naranjania of Jandiala, Karma of Chhina and others suggested to Zakaria Khan to use the occasion to put to the sword the entire Khalsa gathered for the fair.²⁵ Diwan Lakhpat Rai who was part of the Hindu conspiracy undertook to execute the orders when issued by the Governor.

The Sikhs of Lahore got wind of the machinations of the Mughal authorities and ill-disposed Hindus. They informed Bhai Mani Singh who passed on the word to the Sikhs, not to visit Amritsar for the occasion. Some of them who could not be informed reached there. Diwan Lakhpat Rai launched the attack as planned, and put to death a number of Sikhs taking bath in the sacred tank and outside. Harimandar was taken into government possession and Diwali could not be celebrated there.

Bhai Mani Singh protested against the conspiracy and the attack. He was instead called upon to pay the fee of Rs. 5,000. That was part of the story. What rankled in the mind of ill disposed Hindus were his proselytising activities. They were in the forefront in suggesting to his being converted to Islam or put to death²⁶ • In the vitiated atmosphere, it was difficult either for the Qazi or the Governor to resist such pleadings.

As such, Bhai Mani Singh was ordered to be cut to pieces, limb by limb. That was accomplished in June 1734 at *Nakhas*, horse market, outside Delhi Gate, Lahore, where Gurdwara Shahid Gunj stands now²⁷ One of his companions Diwan Singh was broken on the wheels. A number of other persons were also martyred.

Bhai Mani Singh's martyrdom caused a widespread resentment and constituted the landmark in Sikh-Mughal relations. By that time, thanks to his exertions, the Sikhs had, firstly, perfected their concept of the *Granth* and the *Panth*; Secondly, as shown by the debate over the acceptance of *Jagir* and Nawabi, had developed political ambitions to emerge as sovereigns of the Punjab; and, lastly, had developed the mechanics to outlive the worst type of persecution to which they were subjected.

Before the harvesting of 1735, the *Jagir* granted to Nawab Kapur Singh was confiscated. Nawab Kapur Singh's words that Khalsa would now rule over the Punjab instead of the small Jagir helped to fix the parameters and greatly enthused the Sikhs.

The incidents of 1734-35 forced Nawab Kapur Singh alongwith *Buddha Dal* and *Taruna Dal* to move on to Malwa. He busied himself now in administering *pahul*, baptism, and "converted a large number of people - jats, carpenters, weavers, *jhiwars*, *chhatris* and others to the persuasion of Gobind, and the religious respect in which he was held was so great that initiation into the *pahul* of the Guru with his hands was considered a distinction."²⁸

By this time, moving columns of Lahore forces were on the lookout for the Sikhs. In the words of Kanahaya Lal "thousands of Sikhs fell, as a result of these measures."²⁹ The Sikhs in rage had to leave for their resorts in jungles, hills and deserts once again. The Sikhs came in disguise to have bath in Harimandar tank. And once Nawab Kapur Singh captured the Kotwali of Lahore and got released a number of prisoners besides taking care of the weapons.

Another achievement of the Sikhs under Kapur Singh during this period was their successful trampling upon the chiefs of Jhajjar, Dadri, Dujana, Bahadur Garh, Faridabad, Mehrauli and Gurgaon upto the outskirts of Delhi.

Then followed in end 1738, Persian invasion of India. The Sikhs felt elated. Nadir Shah shattered the administrative machinery and ravaged the countryside bringing destruction, desolation and disorder all around the Punjab. After defeating the Mughals at Kamal, he ravaged Delhi and collected a huge booty, including the bejewelled Peacock Throne, the famous Koh-i-Noor diamond (the mountain of light) and thousands of slaves.

For his return journey in 1739, he chose to travel by the foot of the Himalayas to avoid heat. That suited the Khalsa very well to deprive him of a part of the haul including Indian artisans and women. The Khalsa started harassing Nadir Shah's booty laden forces right from their entry into the Punjab down to the river Indus. They deprived him of large part of plunder including men and women, without facing Nadir Shah's army in an open combat. When apprised of the character of the Khalsa whose "houses are their saddles", Nadir Shah perceptibly told Zakaria Khan that "The day is not distant when these rebels will take possession of the country."

The Sikhs gained tremendously. Their exploits against the retreating Persian forces endeared them to the people and greatly added to their prestige and influence, especially when they restored Hindus and Muslims their womenfolk, taken by Nadir Shah's forces as spoils of war.

Zakaria Khan took to heart Nadir Shah's reprimand. He relentlessly pursued the policy of genocide of the Sikhs. The government used its civil and military machine now for the second time to achieve the objective. Regular companies were deputed to search and destroy them. A graded scale of rewards was offered to the people "a blanket for cutting of a Sikh's hair, ten rupees for information of whereabouts of a

Sikh, fifty rupees for a Sikh's scalp. Plunder of Sikh homes was made lawful; giving shelter to Sikhs or withholding information of their movement was made a capital offence." Head-hunting became a gainful occupation. The prominent persons who conducted organised raids of Sikhs heads were Karma of Chhina, Ram Randhawa of Talwandi, Sahib Rai Sandhu of Noshera Dalla, Harbhagat Naranjania and Sain Das of Jandiala, and Dharma Das Topi of Jodh Nagar all Hindus, and Massa Rangar of Mandiala, a Muslim. They brought' cart loads of Sikh's heads for reward. ³² Against that, Adina Beg who took over as *Nazim* of Jalandhar Doab did not crush the Sikhs for his own reasons. This further buttressed the Sikh's sense of discrimination between favourable and hostile Muslims and Hindus on the basis of their performance and not creed.

Massa Rangar committed the heinous crime of converting Harimandar into a dancing hall where he smoked and wined. Mehtab Singh of Mirankot with the help of Sukha Singh of Mari Kambo, disguised as Muslims, entered the precincts of Harimandar in August 1740. Sukha Singh kept the guard, while Mehtab Singh chopped off his head. They made good their escape. With the help of Harbhagat Naranjania, Mehtab Singh was later arrested and, after unspeakable torture on wheels, crushed to death in 1744. Bota Singh who openly challenged the might of Mughal forces was another profile in courage to invite government's wrath.

On Harbhagat Naranjania's complaint, Bhai Taru Singh of his village was arrested and accused of providing rations to the Sikhs. Taru Singh admitted the facts. Nawab Zakaria Khan ordered removal of his scalp. Taru Singh said that the Governor would suffer as much torture. And, Taru Singh would take Zakaria Khan along with him to the other world.

The Nawab's orders were carried out on June 27, 1745. The same day Zakaria Khan's urinary system stopped functioning, putting him in great pains. The Qazi addressed Taru Singh, "O *kafir*, what have you done? The Nawab can't urinate. He is in great pains." Taru Singh told him to take his shoe and beat it on Zakaria's head to make him urinate. On fifth day of shoe beating, Zakaria Khan died on July 1, 1745. On hearing of that, Taru Singh left his mortal remains the same day.

Zakaria Khan has been acclaimed by Hindu historians as a just ruler who did not destroy Hindu temples. Following them, some thoughtless Sikhs too have written in the same vein.³⁴ They ignore the reasons for his lenient treatment of Hindus who were collaborators in his policy of extirpation of the Sikhs. They ignore the immense torture to which the Sikhs were subjected at Nakhas, Lahore. If they want to give him that certificate, they should follow Ishwari Prasad's treatment of invasions of Mahmud of Ghazni. That would make them say that Zakaria Khan to the Hindus of his day was a just ruler and not a fanatic, but to the Sikhs to this day he was a fiend, a devil incarnate.

VIII

The dispute between the sons of Zakaria Khan over succession to the governorship of Lahore enabled the Sikhs to consolidate their position. They assembled on Oiwali, OctQber14, 1745, at Amritsar, and in the first formal *Gurmatta*, the *Sarbat Khalsa* resolved to organise the existing bands ranging from a dozen to larger numbers into 25 sizeable regiments of cavalry under the overall command of Nawab Kapur Singh.³⁵ Some of the commanders of regiments namely Jassa Singh Ahluwalia, Hari Singh Bhangi, Jai Singh Kanahaya, Naudh Singh of Sukrachak played prominent roles in wresting control of the Punjab for the Khalsa. The character of Sikh resistance now changed from hit and run tactics to guerrilla warfare which included organised warfare as well.

The Sikhs attacked Lahore one evening and decamped with a large booty. Yahya Khan who had taken over as Governor asked Oiwan Lakhpat Rai to displace the Sikhs from the nearby swamp haunts. One of the units led by Jassa Singh Ahluwalia on the way to the hills clashed with his younger brother Jaspat Rai and chopped off his head. Lakhpat Rai now in rage vowed to erase the Sikhs from the pages of history.

He got issued a proclamation for general massacre of the Sikhs. All the Sikhs of Lahore were beheaded at *Nakhas* on *amavas*, March 10, 1746, despite a petition by general body of the Hindus that the executions should not take place at least on *amavas*. The Sikh scriptures that fell into his hands were desecrated and destroyed.

Lakhpat Rai with the help of the provincial forces fell upon the Sikhs concentrated in the marshes of Kahnuwan on river Beas. Some cut their way through hostile hillmen to Kiratpur. The main body turned back and after heavy losses crossed the Beas and the Sutlej into Malwa. 7,000 Sikhs were killed, and another 3,000 taken prisoners were executed at *Nakhas*, horse market. The disaster goes by the name of *chhota ghalughara* (small holocaust) (as against great holocaust of 1762).

The fratricidal war (November 1746-March 1747) between Yahya Khan and his younger brother Shah Nawaz gave the Sikhs some respite. The Sikhs met on Baisakhi, March 30, 1747, at Amritsar and resolved (through *gurmatta*) to construct a mud fort named Ram Rauni at Amritsar. This was completed in a short time.

Shah Nawaz who overthrew Yahya Khan was advised by his Oiwan, Kaura Mal, a *Khulasa* Sikh as also Adina Beg to relent in pursuing harsh policy towards the Sikhs because of rising threat of Ahmad Shah Abdali, who after Nadir Shah's murder, had entrenched himself in Afghanistan and was casting covetous eyes on Hindustan. The Sikhs too because of their regards for Kaura Mal de-escalated their guerrilla activity.

Right from the first invasion of Ahmad Shah Abdali in January 1748, the Sikhs had a clear perception of the pattern of things to follow. They had drawn appropriate conclusions from the earlier invasion of Nadir Shah. They recognised that the Mughal rule, because of multiple centres of power and inherent contradictions between them, had become hollow. The Afghans had immense power to bring about an all-around destruction of social, economic, political and cultural ethos of the people and bring about a general anarchy and chaos. To optimise their gains, the Khalsa had to bring about a consolidation of their power under a centralised leadership. The Khalsa knew right from the beginning what was at stake, where their interests lay, and how those were to be achieved. They were clear about their strategy and tactics. The Khalsa welcomed a clash between the Mughals and the Afghans which would lead to their weakening, nay exhaustion, and destruction of each other. They looked amusedly at attempts of the two to retain or regain the sovereignty of the Punjab.

From 1748 to 1765 Ahmad Shah Abdali invaded India, rather Punjab, seven times; his last three invasions from 1766 to 1769 constituted mere predatory incursions. During these 17 years, there was triangular, nay, quadrangular contest for sovereignty of the Punjab.

Starting in December 1747, Ahmad Shah Abdali entered Lahore on January 12, 1748, plundered the suburbs and exacted a heavy tribute. Devastating the towns and countryside, he advanced to Manupur near Sirhind when the Mughal forces led by Wazir Qamaruddin (and on his death in the battle by his son Muinuddin known as Mir Mannu) checked his advance on March II. The failure of the Mughal forces to pursue the retreating forces was reflective of their weaknesses.

The Sikhs moved in to fill the vacuum in central Punjab created by Mughal-Afghan conflict. They, firstly, under the leadership of Jassa Singh Ahluwalia defeated Adina Beg who on Abdali's advance had retired to Hoshiarpur, and, secondly, split the 25 organised regiments into over 60 bands and deprived the retreating Afghans of stores and horses.

On Baisakhi, March 29, 1748, the Sikhs by a *gurmatta* (Guru's resolve) decided to form Dal Khalsa by reorganisation of over 60 *arr:ne~,jathas*, (bands) into eleven associations (*misls*) under the overall leadership' of Jassa. Singh Ahluwalia. Nawab Kapur Singh because of his age sought retirement from active overall leadership. These *misls* were as follows:

1. Ahluwalia, under Jassa Singh Ahluwalia, who was also supreme of all the *misls*.
2. Faisalpuria or Singhpuria, under Nawab Kapur Singh.
3. Sukerchakia under Naudh Singh of Village Sukarchak near Gujranwala.

4. Nishanwalla under Dasaunda Singh, the standard bearer (*nishanwala*) of Dal Khalsa.
5. Bhangi, under Hari Singh of the village Panjwad. (The name came from addiction to *hashish* (*bhang*) of Hari Singh's predecessor Bhuma Singh.
6. Kanahaya, under Jai Singh of village Kahna.
7. Nakkai, under Hira Singh of village Baharwal, situated in a tract near Lahore called Nakka.
8. Dallewalia under Gulab Singh of the village Dalewal.
9. Shaheed, under Deep Singh. The name Shaheed (martyr) came after the martyrdom of the leader.
10. Karora Singhia, under Karora Singh of the village Paijgarh.
11. Ramgarhia under Nand Singh, and later Jassa Singh Ramgarhia.

Phoolkia under Ala Singh of Patiala was the twelfth *misal*, but it was not a part of the Dal Khalsa and sometimes acted against the interests of the community.

The cumulative forces of the 11 *misals* were termed Sarbat Khalsa, the entire Panth. For its democratic functioning, rules were drawn with Akalis, who were stem zealots, responsible for religious affairs at Amritsar, playing a pivotal, supervisory, role.

Mir Mannu took over as Governor of Lahore in April 1748 and sought to establish a strong government. By the time, the Afghans were cleared of the province, three *Doabs* between Chenab and Ravi, Ravi and Beas, Beas and Sutlej were under the Sikh occupation. The Afghans still held Multan.

The main events of the next two decades, when in between the Sikhs took over Lahore and struck coins in 1765 to signify their assumption of sovereignty, may be recalled with advantage.

- * Lahore during the next 17 years, 1748-1765, had fifteen Governors with Mir Mannu covering the first five and a half years. He began as Governor appointed by the Mughals. After the third Abdali invasion of 1751-52, Lahore and Multan became part of Afghan empire, but he continued as Governor. Mughal empire succumbed but in name, after Abdali's invasion in 1755: Marathas entered Delhi and, with the help of Adina Beg, a Machiavellian character, the Sikhs rolled back the Afghans up to Attock. Abdali's next invasion, 1759-1761, shattered Maratha power, but Afghans too were exhausted, to the advantage of the Sikhs. The Sikhs under the patronage of Diwan Kaura Mal, a *Khulasa* Sikh, co-operated with Mir Mannu. This cooperation got snapped on Kaura Mal's death on March 6, 1752, in action during Abdali's third invasion. Thereafter, Mir Mannu as a nominee of Afghans pursued the policy of extirpating them. If nothing else, their women and children were taken to the *Nakhas*, Lahore, in hundreds, were subjected to gruesome torture and martyred there. In 18 months, he killed about 30,000 of them. The peasantry crushed, because of the Afghan depredations and roving provincial troops in search of the Sikh

- families, in large numbers joined the Khalsa fold or offered them protection.
- * After Mir Mannu's death in November 1753, which signalled coming to an end of organised government, the Sikhs filled the vacuum in the administration by offering protection, *rakhi*, on payment of one-fifth of the produce on harvests. After Abdali's 1756-57 invasion, the *rakhi* was recognised by Sarbat Khalsa to constitute the territorial possessions of the *Misls*.
 - * The Sikhs cooperated with Adina Beg and Marathas to oust the Afghans in 1758. They disrupted Abdali's advance during his invasion of 1759-61 to crush the Marathas. With the death of Adina Beg in 1758 there were three claimants to Punjab in Afghans, Mughals and Marathas, but only one master in the Sikhs. In the *wada ghallughara*, great holocaust of 1762, near village Kup, Abdali killed about 30,000 Sikhs - mostly old men, women and children - being escorted to a safer place. The main body of the Sikh fighting force remained intact.
 - * The Sikhs invariably harassed invading Afghan forces during their various invasions by depriving the booty-laden forces of much of the spoils of war besides prisoners, including Hindu and Muslim women. The Sikhs earned wrath of Abdali, who on three occasions, 1757, 1761, and 1762 pulled down Harimandar and defiled the sacred tank by carcasses of cows.
 - * The Sikhs for the first time in 1757 defeated Afghan forces at the battle of Amritsar. That constituted a turning point. The following year, they captured retreating Afghan forces and made them clean up Harimandar and the sacred tank. In October 1762, shortly after the *ghallughara* they again equitably measured sword with the Afghan forces in the battle of Amritsar. In 1764, they captured Lahore and in retaliation spilt hog's blood in the Shahi Mosque. But living up to their character they did not destroy the mosque or kill a single Afghan prisoner in cold blood.

The Sikhs parcelled out Lahore in 1765 between Gujjar Singh and Lehna Singh Bhangi and Sobha Singh of Kanahaya Misl. They forbade plunder and established a non-sectarian and just administration. They struck coins as a mark of sovereignty. Abdali retook Lahore in 1766 and on the people's suggestion offered governorship to Lehna Singh who declined. The people by now were sick of Abdali's incursions, and wanted the Sikh rule to firm up. Syed Bulleh Shah, the Sufi Saint, openly welcomed the Sikh rule. Abdali after another couple of predatory incursions gave up.

The Sikhs being only indigenous people, sons of the soil, involved in the political struggle succeeded in liberating the Punjab from the clutches of foreign rulers. It was a triumph of Khalsa nationalism. Some historians have erroneously put forth the thesis about the rise of Punjabi nationalism. There never was such a thing. The Sikh rule was definitely established with the willing consent of the general populace - Muslims and Hindus.

IX

What brought about that transformation? How the Sikhs found general acceptance? Here are some of the reasons.

Firstly, the repeated invasions of Ahmad Shah Abdali, helped to bring about a general chaos and anarchy, a high degree of economic and public insecurity (*khadha pita lahe da, rehnda Ahmad Shah da*), and a personal tragedy for a large body of population, irrespective of caste, creed or religion.

Secondly, the contest between the Mughals and the Afghans both of them Muslims, and the Afghans plundering expeditions against the Muslims and the non-Muslims equally, weakened the Muslims' euphoria for their co-religionists. It made them understand that they were co-sharers in adversity along with other people. This tended to break the religious barriers between various communities and highlighted the geographical compulsions, of being residents of a particular place and province, making the ground fertile for the Sikhs, the only indigenous force operating at the time.

Thirdly, the deeds of the Khalsa at first in depriving the invaders of the booty and the Indian prisoners, including women, and later confronting the invaders, in the process teaching them a lesson, put a new heart in the populace. This made them look towards the deeds of the Sikhs in a favourable light and as a ray of hope for the delivery of the province from the obnoxious invaders and plunderers from the outside. The exploits of the Sikhs in recovery of the Hindu and Muslim women from the clutches of invaders and their restoration to their families gave birth to a Punjabi adage, "*Chhaie, ke run gae Basre, Ke mori baba dang valia Sardara*" - alluding to the abduction and sale of Indian woman at Basra market, and appealing to the Sikh armed brothers to retrieve them. This spoke volumes about the popularity of the Khalsa especially during Ahmad Shah's invasions.

Lastly, the sterling qualities and purity of character maintained by the Khalsa including their commitment to secular ideals - lack of discrimination in treatment towards the general body of Hindus and Muslims, earned them a general acceptability. In the words of Qazi Nur Mohammad, the Sikhs were the "beau ideal of a human being and were popular among the people of the Punjab." Mind it; he is using the word "people of the Punjab", and not Hindus or Muslims.

Qazi Nur Mohammad, it may be recalled, came in the train of Ahmad Shah Abdali in 1764, was a participant in the fight against the Sikhs, and was a keen observer of things around him. He wrote that Sikhism was a religion distinct from Hindus. He also made some telling remarks about the character of the Sikhs. In his testimony:

1. "They (the Sikhs) never kill a coward and do not obstruct one who flees from the field". (They seldom resort to cold blooded murder even of their enemies).

2. They respect the chastity of women as part of their faith and honour: "adultery does not exist among them."
3. "They do not rob a woman of her gold and ornaments, may she be a queen or a slave girl".
4. They "never resort to stealing and no thief exists among them and they do not keep company with the adulterer and the thief."
5. "When in festivities, they surpass Hatim (in generosity)".J7

Coming from the pen of a bigoted Qazi, who otherwise used most offensive expressions against the Sikhs (whom he called dogs), their religion and their Gurus, these remarks, firstly, explain the reasons which made the Sikhs the "beau ideals" of the people and, secondly, represented the general characteristics of the Khalsa throughout the period from 1708 onwards.³⁸ The ideals laid down by Banda Singh as spelled out by Ghulam Mohyuddin (1722-23) were strictly followed by the Khalsa during the period.

The Sikhs emerged sovereigns of the Punjab but had to pay a very heavy price. They were subjected to worst type of persecution, and thrice during the period the authorities pursued the policy of genocide - all out extirpation. Really, two hundred thousand Sikhs were put to death during the period.³⁹ Three generations of the Sikhs perished before they emerged sovereigns of the Punjab.

The question for the young nascent community was one of survival.

This helped to bring about certain distortions in the Sikh psyche. Guru Gobind Singh was a saint, a soldier, a scholar par excellence, all combined in one. He ordained the Khalsa in his own image and envisioned it to combine all the three characteristics. Face to face with the struggle for their very survival, the Sikhs came to lay overemphasis on the martial character of the Khalsa at the cost of intellectual and dialectical characteristics. Consequently, in the 18th century, after Bhai Mani Singh, the Sikhs failed to produce an intellectual of that calibre, much less a group of them, to write about the account of Sikhs' struggle for survival, the tactics adopted by the Khalsa to overcome their handicaps, and their guerrilla tactics which they successfully applied against the mighty Mughal and Afghan forces. Not even about Sikh religion and philosophy, much less to guard the Khalsa against Brahminical designs to subvert it from within.

The mass scale entrants to the *Panth* during 1750s and after, especially after the death of Nawab Kapur Singh in 1752, could not be imparted indepth grounding and schooling in Sikhism. That affected the orientation of the community which was quite discernible during the period of the Sikh rule, both the *Misls* and the Kingdom under Ranjit Singh and his successors.

X

The three and a half decades of *Misaldari*⁴⁰ period when the Punjab was parcelled out in an incongruous manner between the various *Misls*, and the enterprising Sikh Sardars holding their sway in the areas between the Sutlej and the Yamuna, reflected a classic picture of a fractured leadership. Its only advantage was that sooner, in mid-1760s, the Sikh *Misls* swept over the Punjab and established their sway.

Jassa Singh Ahluwalia had been overall in charge of the eleven *Misls* and at one time had been proclaimed *Sultan-ul-Quom*, the supreme leader of the nation. But no effort was made to weave the *Misls* into a federal set up. Jassa Singh Ramgarhia needed to be disciplined.

Significantly, around the same period, the thirteen American colonies which had overthrown the colonial rule, had coalesced to set up a federation, however weak, of the United States of America, under the powerful leadership of George Washington. The Sikh *misls* failed to throw up such a leadership, principally because they had neglected intellectual dialecticism and the art of reasoning. There was no one to put forth a synthesis of Sikh commonwealth as a logical outcome of the hard won Sikh struggle.

This reflected, inter alia, the failure of Jassa Singh Ahluwalia to assert his leadership, and of the Akalis at Akal Takht to analyse the emerging scenario. Not surprisingly, the institutions of *Sarbat Khalsa* and *gurmatta* which had done good to the *Panth* in dire times, fell into disuse⁴¹ • There was all round failure of corporate leadership of the *Panth* at the time of triumph. They lacked vision to think ahead.

For about two decades, the ground situation in northern India was conducive for the Sikhs to extend their dominion to the Gangetic valley and into Rajputana. The Afghan had got exhausted and retreated from Punjab. The Mughals had collapsed. The Marathas were a spent force. The English were still far away. Rohillas, Jats, Rajputs and the Nawab of Oudh were weak, disunited and declining.⁴²

The Sikhs had the power. They were the only reckonable force at the time. But they lacked imagination and unity of purpose. They had no overall plan-outline to move in a systematic manner, and a well defined objective to achieve. They lacked the concept of power to collaborate and consolidate. Their seventeen incursions in over two decades (1763-88) led them to levy *rakhi* in the Gangetic "valley, but these proved predatory after the appointment of Mahadji Scindia as Vizir-ul-Mutlak of Shah Alam in December 1784, when the imperial defences were strengthened. The Sikhs were wiser after the event.⁴³ But the hands of the clock could not be put back. Their efforts to set things aright came to naught. It only showed their bankruptcy of competent leadership.

It was worse that in the absence of threat from without, the *Misls* in a decade were on the cantankerous path, often at loggerheads with one another. They formed leagues within themselves or aligned with outside forces like Raja of Jammu to fight against each other over trivial matters. There was all round growth of petty jealousies. The *Panth* counted for nothing. Brahminical, educated, Hindus fished in troubled waters.

The *Misls* were woken, as if from a slumber, by the recrudescence of the Afghan invasions under Shah Zaman, grandson of Ahmad Shah Abdali, who ascended the throne at the age of 23 in 1793. He was much influenced by invitations from the Mughal King of Delhi, Rohilla Chief of Rampur, Tipu Sultan of Mysore and even the ruler of Kangra. They invited him to invade India for diverse reasons. He told the Mughals and Rohillas that he was coming to chastise the Sikhs. From the Sikhs, he sought passage through Punjab to chastise the Marathas.

Presented with the demand, the *Misl* chiefs were agreeable to give him passage. But young Ranjit Singh Sukarchakia (b. 1780) grandson of Charhat Singh then a young sibling according to the British records said, "My presents will be personally delivered to the Shah on the field of battle." Shah Zaman made three attempts to capture Lahore. He had to beat a hasty retreat in January 1796 because of troubles at home. Later in the year, he did capture Lahore when the *Misl* chiefs retired from the city. The Sikhs gathered at Amritsar to defend the holy city. In the reckless hand to hand fight at Amritsar on January 12, 1797, Shah Zaman lost 20,000 of his choicest soldiers against 15,000 Sikhs who pursued the retreating Afghans up to the outskirts of Lahore.

Ranjit Singh with his 9,000 troops was made responsible for security of the holy city. That marked the beginning of the rise of Ranjit Singh. Shah Zaman sought to conciliate the Sikhs during his next two invasions in 1797 and 1798. His overrunning the Punjab to Lahore was demoralising to the people. He, however, had to beat a hasty retreat because of Persian invasion and revolt of his half brother Mahmud, never to return to Punjab.

Because of his exploits against Shah Zaman, Ranjit Singh's stock rose in the estimation of the people. Men of all communities in Lahore petitioned him to capture the city and take them under his protection. His capture of Lahore in July 1799 without any resistance marked the death knell of the *misaldari* system and the beginnings of the rise of Sikh monarchy.

XI

During the *Misl* period and of the monarchy of Ranjit Singh, no concerted effort was made to instill the teachings of the Gurus in the people's mind or take care to keep those teachings in their pristine purity.⁴⁵ After Nawab Kapur Singh's death especially, the Brahminical subverters had the heyday. This neglect proved very

costly. The Sikh values were eroded and corroded in a subtle and not so subtle a manner. Because of Sikh Sardars' carelessness, Brahminical ritualism took hold of the common man of all denominations - Hindus, Sikhs and Muslims alike. The Brahmins were aided and abetted by *Udasis* and *Nirmalas*.

The *Udasis* had earlier, during the period of persecution of the Sikhs, managed the Gurdwaras but did nothing to promote Sikhism. They were far from the Khalsa fold. Over time, they had relapsed into old Hindu practices and emerged as a monastic order. With the grant of *Jagirs*, land grants, to the Sikh shrines, their outlook became all the more sinister. They did not encourage the participation of Sikh *sangat* in the management of the shrines, and the Gurdwaras progressively became like Hindu temples.

They began to present ten Gurus as *A vatars* of Vishnu and Sri Guru Granth Sahib as the fifth Veda.

Then there were *Nirmalas* who did provide teaching of Gurmukhi alphabets and of the Sikh scriptures. Because of their Vedantic interpretation of the Sikh scriptures, their impact was not wholesome. They provided the groundswell in which the activities of *Udasis* and Brahmins could not be looked with disdain. The *Nirmalas* began to establish *deras*, hospices, wherein they began to practise Hindu rites for births and deaths, and guidance regarding Hindu *sahas* and *nakshatra*, auspicious or inauspicious days, and astrological fixtures. They ceased to provide correct lead to the community. This went on during the period of Ranjit Singh too.

It was all the more reprehensible that distortions were made in the second half of 18th century by subverting the Sikh theology and orientation. To begin with, the bulk of peasantry which came within the fold of the Khalsa in 1750s could not be properly initiated into the Khalsa code of conduct. The Afghan depredations and the vacuum in the Sikh leadership following the death in 1752 of Nawab Kapur Singh, who had carried on the work of Bhai Mani Singh, were the main factors. Then came a concerted effort by the caste Hindus (including the scions of families like those of Rama Randhawa, Kanna Chhina and numerous others who had actively collaborated with the Mughals in persecution of the Sikhs) following the rupture in their equation with the Mughal administration in the wake of Abdali's invasions, to join the Khalsa fold. They did so not out of conviction, but for tactical reasons, to safeguard Hindu interests and subvert the Sikh movement from within.- _